A GUIDE FOR COUPLES

How couples therapy works

Integrative Behavioral Couple Therapy (IBCT), explained step by step



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WHAT IS IBCT

Two lines of work at the same time

IBCT stands for Integrative Behavioral Couple Therapy. It was developed by psychologists Andrew Christensen and Neil Jacobson in the United States.



Acceptance

Understanding the differences that are part of who each of you is, so they stop turning into a fight every time they show up.



Change

Practicing new ways to talk, share tasks and solve everyday problems.

134 seriously distressed couples took part in the main IBCT study. Five years after treatment, about half still showed significant improvement.

WHERE CONFLICT COMES FROM

Three ingredients usually show up together



Real differences

Pace, organization, spending habits, wanting time together or time alone, cultural customs.



Sensitivities

Past experiences that make some topics hurt more. Example: someone who was criticized a lot may hear any request as an attack.



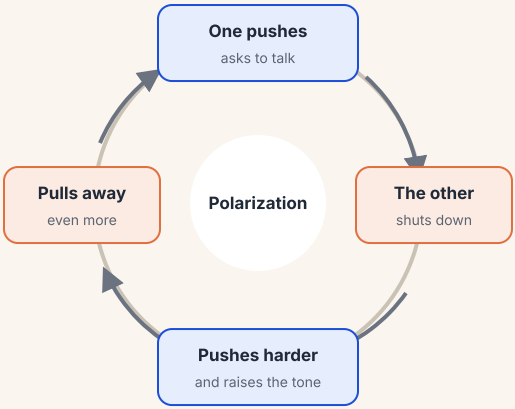
Outside stress

Work, children, money, health, distance, moving to another country. These wear down both partners' patience.

None of these ingredients makes anyone guilty. The trouble shows up in how the couple reacts to them, which is the topic of the next page.

THE CYCLE

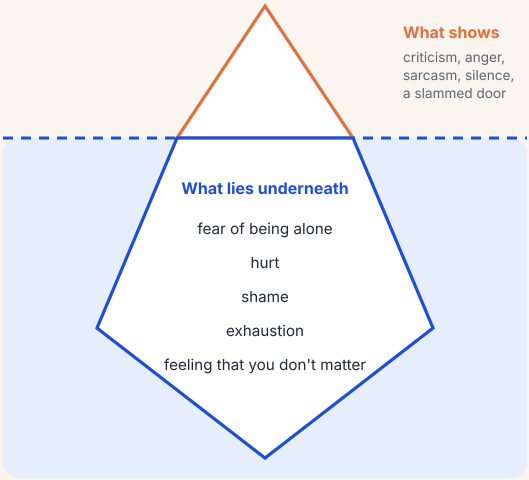
Each partner's reaction feeds the other's



Polarization happens when each partner moves to an opposite extreme on the same issue. The drawing shows a common example. Over time, the couple starts fighting about the cycle itself, and the original issue fades into the background. In therapy, the cycle becomes the focus, because both partners take part in it.

WHAT LIES UNDERNEATH

In a fight, each partner only sees the other's tip



Each partner reacts to the other's tip and answers with their own. Part of the work in therapy is bringing what lies underneath into the conversation, because hearing the other's hurt usually lowers the urge to defend yourself.

THE STAGES

First understand, then intervene

ASSESSMENT · ABOUT 4 MEETINGS

1. **Online questionnaires**
   Each partner answers alone, on their own link. It takes 20 to 25 minutes.

2. **First joint session**
   What brought you here, how the relationship started and what you have already tried.

3. **Individual sessions**
   One with each partner: personal history and past relationships.

4. **Feedback session**
   The therapist presents a picture of the couple, and you decide whether and how to continue.

TREATMENT · LENGTH AGREED AT THE FEEDBACK SESSION

5. **Treatment sessions**
   Real episodes from your week, plus acceptance and change tools.

6. **Review and closing**
   You assess your progress, and sessions become less frequent.

THE FEEDBACK SESSION

A picture of the couple in four parts

At the end of the assessment, the therapist brings together what came up in the sessions and in the questionnaires.

Differences
How you two differ

Sensitivities
What hurts most for each of you

Stressors
What weighs on you from outside

Pattern
The cycle you keep repeating

You can correct anything that doesn't fit. The treatment plan comes out of this conversation.

IN SESSION · ACCEPTANCE

Tools for understanding each other



Empathic joining

Each partner shares what they felt beneath the reaction. Example: "when you came home late, I was afraid I wasn't a priority."



Looking at the problem from outside

You describe the cycle as something that sits between the two of you and give it a name, like "the push-and-vanish cycle." That makes it easier to talk about without blaming.



Tolerance

You rehearse a difficult situation in session and agree on how to react when it happens again at home.

IN SESSION · CHANGE

Tools for doing things differently



Exchanging gestures

Each partner picks small actions the other enjoys and puts them into practice during the week.



Communication training

Talking about what you feel and need. Before answering, summing up what you heard from your partner.



Problem solving

Defining the problem in one sentence, listing options and making an agreement with a date to review it.

Change tools work better once the couple fights less about the cycle. That is why the order and the amount are agreed with you.

BETWEEN SESSIONS

Session material comes from your week

Most sessions revolve around a real episode: a fight, a moment of distance or a good moment.

Episode of the week

What happened

What I felt

What I did

How it ended

- [x] Jot down on your phone, in a few lines, the episodes that stood out during the week.
- [x] Bring the most recent episode, even if it seems small.
- [x] If an agreed task didn't work out, bring the reason. It also helps to understand the cycle.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Common questions before starting

Will the therapist say who is right?

No. The focus is the pattern you both repeat. Each partner plays their own part in it.

What if only one of us wants therapy?

Couple sessions need both partners. If one is unsure, the assessment helps you decide whether it makes sense to continue.

Can sessions be in English?

Yes. Sessions and questionnaires can be in English or Portuguese.

Will therapy save the relationship?

The goal is for you to understand the cycle and decide with more clarity. Some couples come out closer; others decide to separate with less suffering.

BEFORE THE FIRST SESSION

An important note

If there is physical aggression, threats, or fear of saying something in front of your partner, mention it in your individual session or in the questionnaire. In these cases, the therapist may recommend a different kind of care before couples therapy.

To get the most out of it

- [x] Read this guide, together or separately.
- [x] Answer the questionnaires before your first individual session.
- [x] Write down your questions and bring them to the joint session.



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